

60 YEARS OF FREEDOM

Crouching tiger, hidden dragon

The legendary Unniyaarcha was queen of the ancient art of Kalaripayat beating her adversaries to a pulp. Modern, young women in Kerala are all set to take her place.

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

A crimson sun is setting over the Arabian Sea edging the palm-lined Kovalam beach in Thiruvananthapuram. Sheena, 19, and Bijitha, 16, have been practising for hours. Despite the achingly back-breaking long hours in the kalarithara (Kalari practice ground) under the exacting eyes of their *asaan* (master), the scrawny girls don't betray even the slightest signs of exhaustion. Their eyes gleam and swords flash as Bijitha and Sheena crouch like tigresses to encounter Selvan, their much more seasoned and powerful male colleague, who leaps at them like a hidden dragon.

Kalaripayat, Kerala's traditional martial arts, believed to be the origin of karate and kung-fu, has always celebrated women. The famed ballads that embellish the ancient kalaripayat narrate heroics of many femmes fatale—predominantly Unniyaarcha who would make mincemeat of her male adversaries. But as social mores changed, so did the status of women, with the ballads being reduced to myths. Kalaripayat became a male preserve in a state where women have traditionally enjoyed a much higher status than elsewhere in the country. But things are morphing now and women are once again claiming their rightful place in the kalarithara.

"Women are coming to learn Kalari in large numbers. Perhaps they are preparing themselves, to counter the increasing incidence of violence against women" says G. Radhakrishnan, *asaan* at the Bodhidharma Kalari Sangham at Poonthura, Thiruvananthapuram. "It gives me more confidence," says Bijitha, a Class XI student who has been learning Kalari for six years. "I am worried about stories which abound in newspapers of women getting attacked," she says. Sheena, who has been learning since she was five years old, wants to become a Kalari teacher. "There are not many women teaching this art," she says. Sheena has three sisters and all of them have been put through the rigorous Kalari training. "My father and I are Kalari *asaans*. I knew I would teach my children Kalari even if all of them were daughters," says K. Babu, her father. Radhakrishnan says even housewives with children are joining Kalari classes. "Muslim women never used to come in the past. Today they are also taking to Kalari in large numbers," he says. As the blades flash in the dying light, an ancient art form comes alive.

5 WEAPONS ARE USED IN KALARI THAT INCLUDE SWORD, SHIELD, DAGGER, SPEAR, SHORT STICKS

MARTIAL ARTS

Thiruvananthapuram KERALA

